

ART & CULTURE



INDIAN ARCHITECTURE

MODULE - 18

- GUPTA PERIOD ART
- TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

ART AND CULTURE IN THE GUPTA PERIOD



Mural Paintings of Ajanta

1 Art and culture indeed reached its zenith during this period which included Hindu, Buddhist, and Jain art.

2 The salient contribution/elements of art and culture of this period is described below:

3 **Paintings at Ajanta:**

- The mural paintings of Ajanta are a contribution of this age, although, earlier the Satavahanas and later the Vakatakas have also contributed to it.
- The paintings include images of Bodhisattvas and Jatakas.

ART AND CULTURE IN THE GUPTA PERIOD



Dashavatara temple at Deogarh

4

Sculptures in Gupta Period:

- The **Dashavatara temple at Deogarh (UP)** which contains the reclining image of Vishnu is a grand example of this age's sculpture.
- During this phase, both the Gandhara and Mathura school of art flourished.
- The image of Vishnu at Mathura and seated image of Buddha at Sarnath during this period are the finest examples of sculptures.
- The **sculptures of Varaha at Udayagiri caves near Vidisha (Madhya Pradesh)** is another example of great craftsmanship.
- Further, the standing image of Buddha at Mathura and Buddha's bronze statue are other great examples of sculptures the influences of puranic Hinduism as well as Buddhism.

ART AND CULTURE IN THE GUPTA PERIOD



Chaturmukhlinga Shiva temple at Nachana

- 5 Temple architecture evolved during this period as seen from Dashavatara stone temple (Deogarh) and the Chaturmukhlinga Shiva temple at Nachana (Madhya Pradesh).
- 6 Cave and rock-cut sculpture flourished during this period. This is evident in the Udayagiri caves and the Elephanta caves (5th to 8th century CE). The latter has the famous Trimurti sculpture.

ART AND CULTURE IN THE GUPTA PERIOD

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Coins:

- A number of gold and silver coins of this age have been discovered.
- These show images of Samudragupta holding royal sceptre, holding bow, performing Ashwamedha Yagna, playing Veena, etc.
- Coins with images of other rulers are also found.



Samudragupta playing veena



Learning Space

GUPTA PERIOD: CLASSIC AGE

- 1** The Gupta period can thus be described as 'Classic' in the sense of the degree of perfection it achieved- something that was never achieved before and has seldom been achieved since- in the perfect balance and harmony of all elements in style and iconography.
- 2** The Guptas were Brahmanical by religion with special devotion to Vishnu, but they showed exemplary tolerance for both Buddhism and Jainism.
- 3** Puranic Hinduism with its three deities- Vishnu, Shiva, and Shakti , as the consort of Shiva – came to the forefront.
- 4** While Shaivism developed in the south and south-east and Shaktism in eastern India and in some parts of south-west Malabar, Vaishnavism, with its emphasis on Krishna as its main exponent, flourished mostly in the northern and central parts of India.

GUPTA TEMPLE STYLES

- 1** The setting up of sanctuaries for the images of gods goes back perhaps to the second century BC.
- 2** The devagrahas of the pre-Christian centuries which have been excavated are in an extremely fragmentary state.
- 3** Built of perishable materials they apparently afforded little scope for architectural principles.
- 4** It was in the Gupta period that building with lasting materials began, such as dressed stone and brick.
- 5** The Gupta period marks the beginning of Indian temple architecture.

THE BASIC FORM OF THE HINDU TEMPLE

The basic form of the Hindu temple comprises the following:



Garbhagriha

- 1** A cave-like sanctum (garbhagriha literally 'womb-house'), which, in the early temples, was a **small cubicle** with a single entrance and grew into a larger chamber in time.
- 2** The garbhagriha is made to house the main icon which is itself the **focus of much ritual attention**.

THE BASIC FORM OF THE HINDU TEMPLE

The basic form of the Hindu temple comprises the following:

3

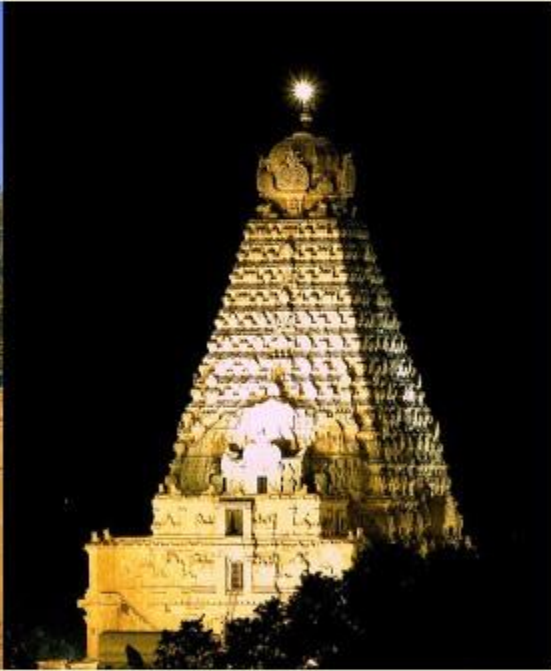
The entrance to the temple which may be a portico or colonnaded hall that incorporates space for a large number of worshippers and is known as a mandapa.



THE BASIC FORM OF THE HINDU TEMPLE



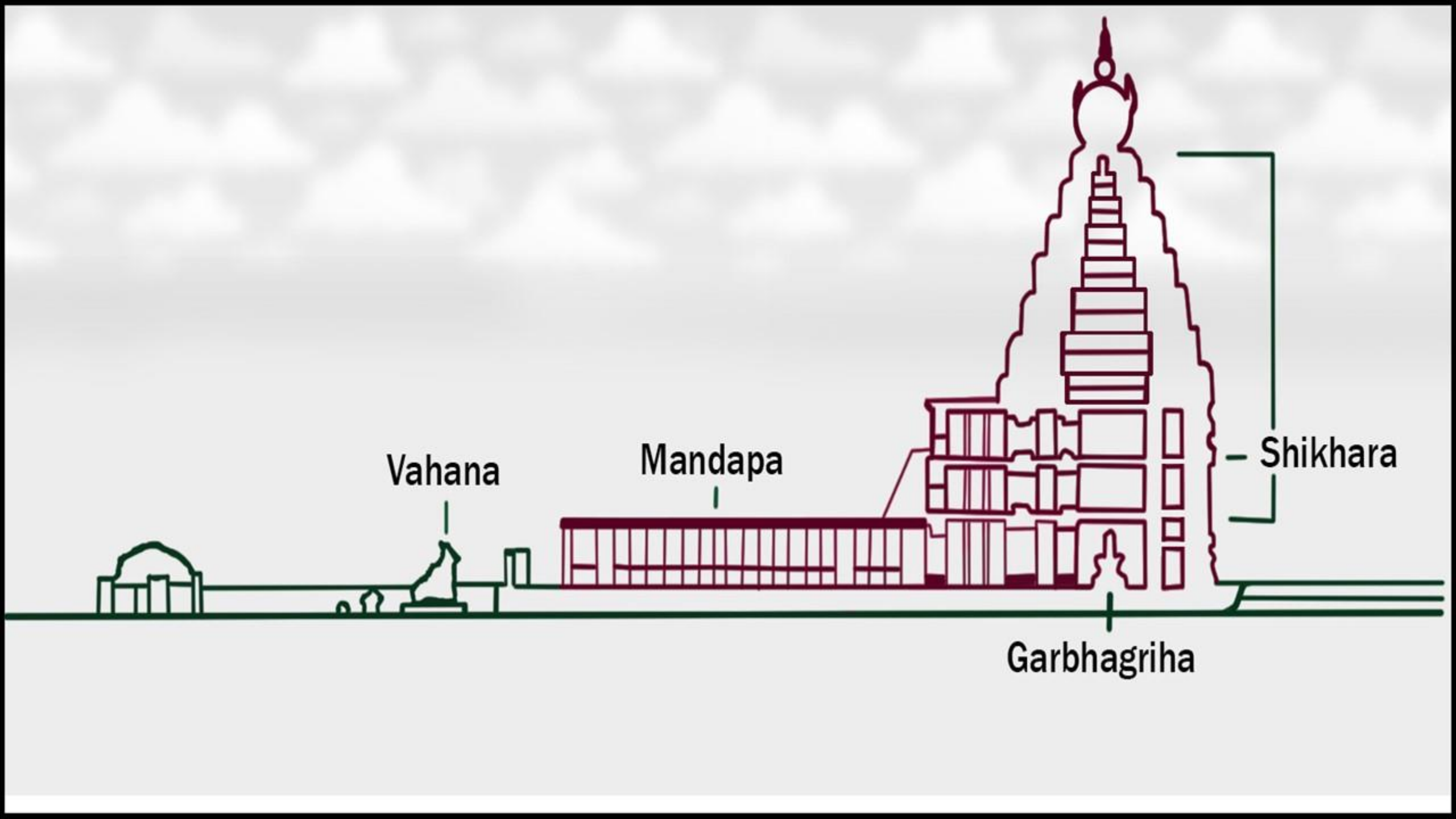
Shikara



Vimana

4

From the fifth century CE onwards, freestanding temples tend to have a mountain like spire, which can take the shape of a curving shikhar in North India and a pyramidal tower, called a vimana in South India.



Vahana

Mandapa

Garbhagriha

Shikhara

THE BASIC FORM OF THE HINDU TEMPLE

- 5 The vahan, i.e., the mount or vehicle of the temple's main deity along with a standard pillar or dhvaj is placed axially before the sanctum.



Dhvaj

Vahan

THE BASIC FORM OF THE HINDU TEMPLE



Nagara style

Dravidian style

- 6 Two broad orders of temples in the country are known— **Nagara** in the north and **Dravida** in the south.
- 7 At times, the **Vesar style** of temples as an independent style created through the selective mixing of the Nagara and Dravida orders is mentioned by some scholars. Elaborate studies are available on the various sub-styles within these orders.

SCULPTURE, ICONOGRAPHY AND ORNAMENTATION



Iconography in temples

- 1 The study of images of deities falls within a branch of art history called 'iconography', which consists of identification of images based on certain symbols and mythologies associated with them.
- 2 Every region and period produced its own distinct style of images with its regional variations in iconography.
- 3 The temple is covered with elaborate sculpture and ornament that form a fundamental part of its conception.

SCULPTURE, ICONOGRAPHY AND ORNAMENTATION



**Dvarapala of
Brihadeeswara temple**

4

The placement of an image in a temple is carefully planned for instance,

- **River goddesses** (Ganga and Yamuna) are usually found at the entrance of a garbhagriha in a **Nagara temple**,
- **Dvarapalas** (doorkeepers) are usually found on the gateways or gopurams of **Dravida temples**,
- Similarly, **mithunas** (erotic images), **navagrahas** (the nine auspicious planets) and **yakshas** are also placed at entrances to guard them.

SCULPTURE, ICONOGRAPHY AND ORNAMENTATION



The Ashtadikpalas

- 5 Various forms or aspects of the main divinity are to be found on the outer walls of the sanctum.
- 6 The deities of directions, i.e., the ashtadikpalas face the eight key directions on the outer walls of the sanctum and/or on the outer walls of a temple.

SCULPTURE, ICONOGRAPHY AND ORNAMENTATION



KALASHA

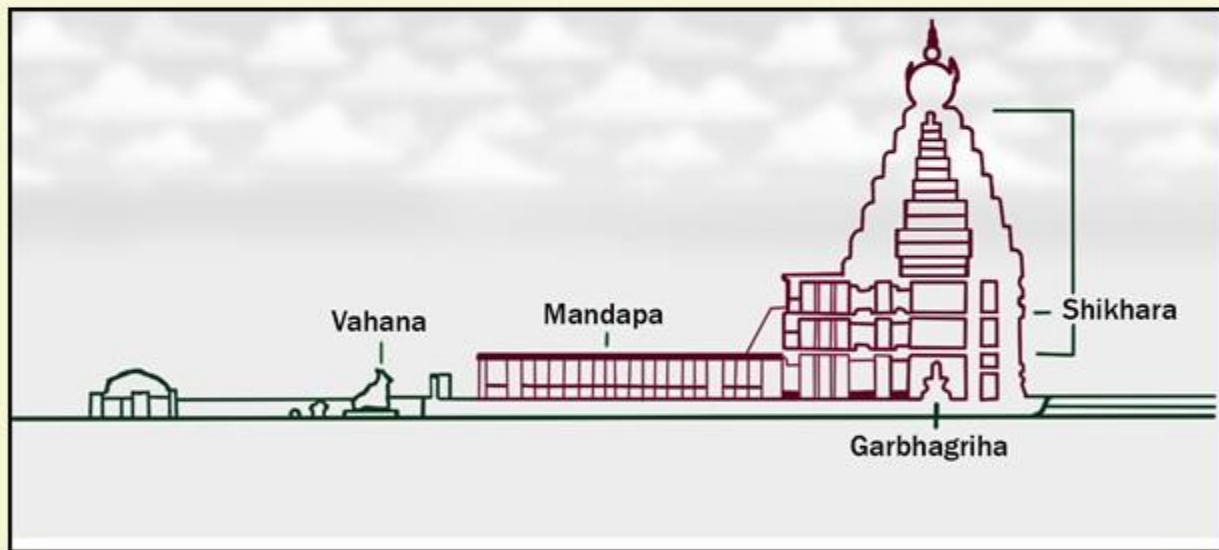
Kalasha



Yali

- 7 Subsidiary shrines around the main temple are dedicated to the family or incarnations of the main deity.
- 8 Finally, various elements of ornamentation such as gavaksha, vyala/yali, kalpalata, amalaka, kalasha, etc. are used in distinct ways and places in a temple.

SUMMARY OF TEMPLE STRUCTURE



The basic form of the Hindu temple comprises the following:

- **Sanctum Sanctorum:** Also known as Garbhagriha (literally womb-house) is a small room, generally cubicle, which houses the principal deity of the temple.
- **Mandapa:** It is entrance to the temple. It may be a portico or a hall and is generally designed to house a large number of worshippers.
- **Shikhara:** It is a mountain like spire. The shapes varied from pyramidal to curvilinear.
- **Vahana:** It is the mount or vehicle of the main deity and was placed just before the sanctum sanctorum.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE



Nagara style



Dravida style



Vesara style

- 1 Temple architecture, with the development of a square sanctum and a pillared portico emerged during the Gupta period.
- 2 There was a gradual progression from the flat-roofed monolithic temples in the initial stages to the sculptured “Shikhara” in the later years. The progression can be distinguished into five stages:

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

FIRST STAGE



Temple No. 17 at Sanchi

The features of the temple developed during this phase are:

- The temples had **flat roof**.
- The temples were **square in shape**.
- The portico was developed on shallow pillars.
- The entire structure was built on **low platforms**.
- Example : Temple No. 17 at Sanchi.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

SECOND STAGE



Parvati temple at Nachna

- The temples built during this phase continued most of the features of the earlier phase. However, the platforms were higher or upraised.
- Some instances of two-storied temples have also been found.
- Another important addition of this phase was a covered ambulatory passageway around the sanctum sanctorum or garbhagriha.
- The passageway was used as a pradakshina path.
- Example: Parvati temple at Nachna Kuthara in Madhya Pradesh

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

THIRD STAGE

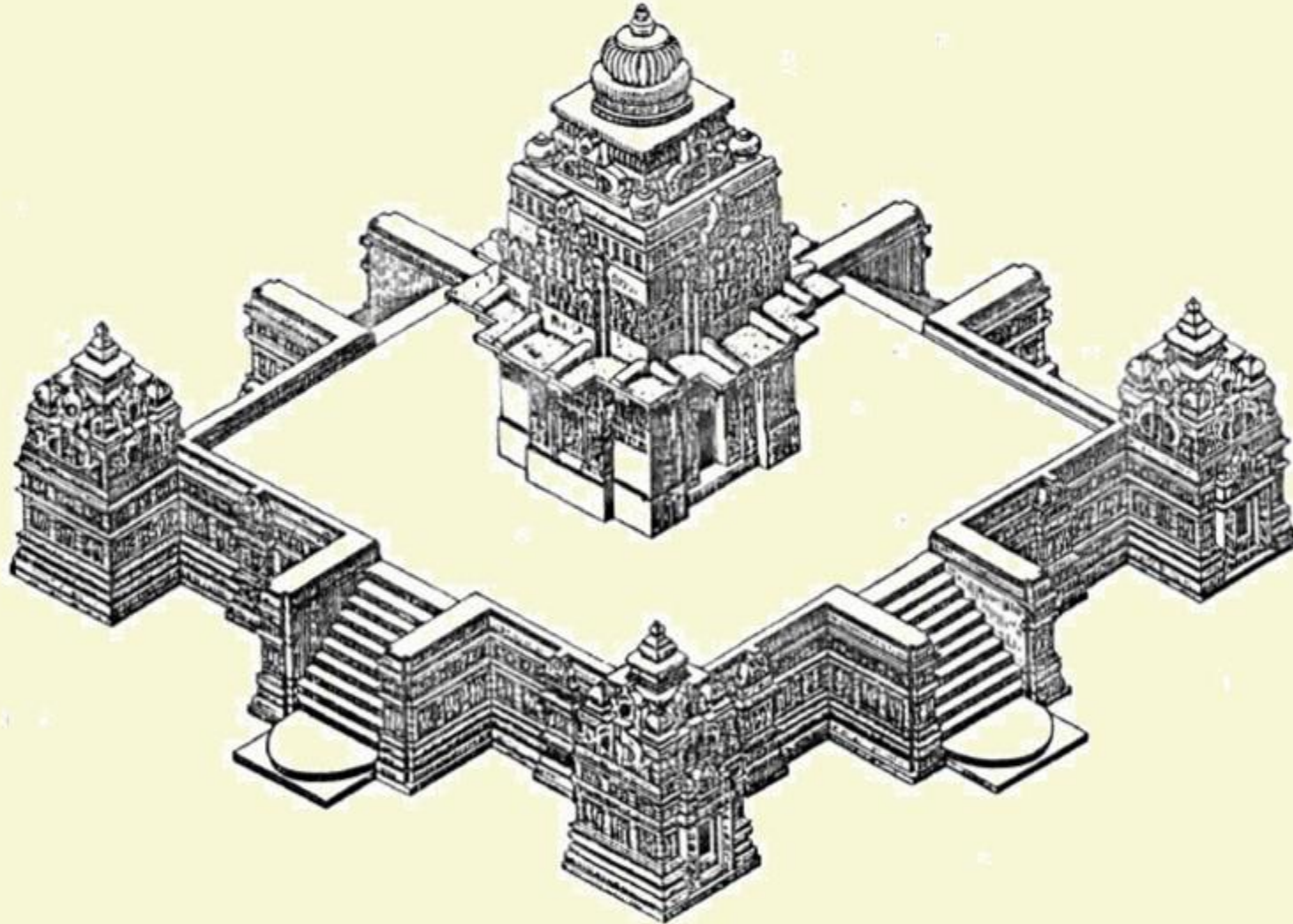


Dashavatara temple at Deogarh

- This stage saw the **emergence of Shikharas in place of a flat roof**. However, they were still quite low and almost square.
- **Panchayatan style of temple making was introduced.**
- In the Panchayatan style of temple making, there were **four subsidiary shrines along with the temple of the principal deity**. The main temple was square with an elongated mandap in front of it, giving it a rectangular shape.
- The subsidiary shrines were placed opposite to each other on either side of the mandap.
- Example: Dashavatar temple at Deogarh (UP) Durga temple at Aihole (Karnataka) etc.

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

THIRD STAGE



Panchayatana style of Deogarh temple

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE



Maniyar Math at Rajgir

FOURTH STAGE

- The temples of this stage were almost similar, **except the main shrine became more rectangular.**
- Example Ter temple at Sholapur

FIFTH STAGE

- In this stage, there was the **introduction of circular temples** with shallow rectangular projections.
- Rest of the features of the previous stage continued.
- Example: Maniyar Math at Rajgir

TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE



Nagara style



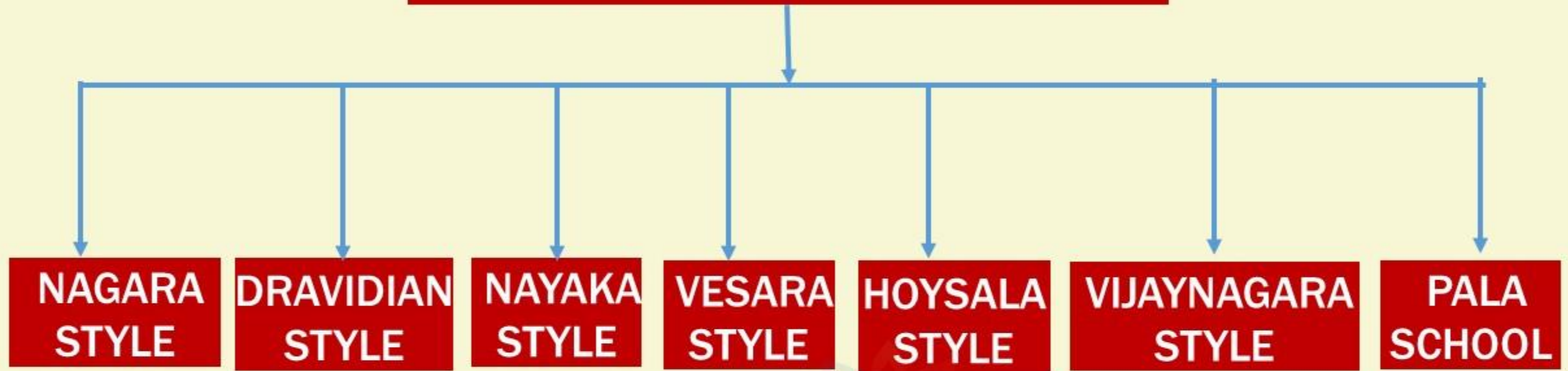
Dravida style



Vesara style

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STYLE OF TEMPLE ARCHITECTURES



Under the patronage of the local rulers, different styles of architecture developed in the different regions of India as given above. We shall analyse each styles of temple architecture in the forthcoming modules.

PRELIMS 2014

With reference to the cultural history of India, the term 'Panchayatan' refers to:

- A. An assembly of elders
- B. A religious sect
- C. A style of temple construction
- D. An administrative functionary

Answer: C

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